many of them had diplomas and degrees, but these looked best framed on the wall and rarely impressed any employer. Their parents had spent good money to send them to an engineering college, a vocational or management institute, but with little reward. It is widely acknowledged that more than 60 per cent of those with formal vocational skills work in areas they are not trained for.

It is then not for want of trying that these young people face a bleak prospect as they enter full-fledged adulthood. Today, as many as 96 per cent of school-age children are enrolled; currently their numbers have shot up in private schools from a mere 2 per cent in 1980 to 34 per cent. Over the past years, we have established nearly 800 universities with 24 million students as well as 6,000 engineering colleges with over 2 million students. These figures show a sharp rise, way higher than a gradual climb. Ambitions have simply skyrocketed.

In contrast, the parents of this new youthful generation were from a different world. They were less discontented, less educated and more rural with limited ambitions beyond making ends meet and dying respectably. All that has changed; the rural world cannot retain their young, nor do their parents want them to relive the lives they had led. Unsurprisingly, over 60 per cent of rural net domestic product is now non-agricultural, which is why workshops are abuzz in every village and slum. Hence the willingness of parents to finance education with the hope and prayer that the fates that visited them will not haunt their children.

The accent was not on jobs for locals or special handouts...but to bleach politics of politicians who are the source of all undemocratic evil

Why then should good, hard-earned money spent on education and skill development lead to wasted ambitions? If, after all, the hardship their parents had endured, they should still be locked into low-paying, uncertain jobs, then it must be age-blind corruption that is at the bottom of it all. The way out then is to change the rules of the game, beginning with a citizen's charter and watchdog Lokpals that would nail the corrupt and free the passage to a robust democracy. This is probably all the sociology needed to background the anti-corruption movement that buoyed Anna Hazare.

The accent was, therefore, not on jobs for locals or special handouts, nor political vendetta but to bleach politics of politicians who are the source of all undemocratic evil. An impossible, oxymoronic idea that only the very young can entertain. Consequently, it was Anna's outsider status that drew him to the cheering crowd of youthful enthusiasts who looked up to him despite his age. That a septuagenarian became the leader

